AI × Labour Markets

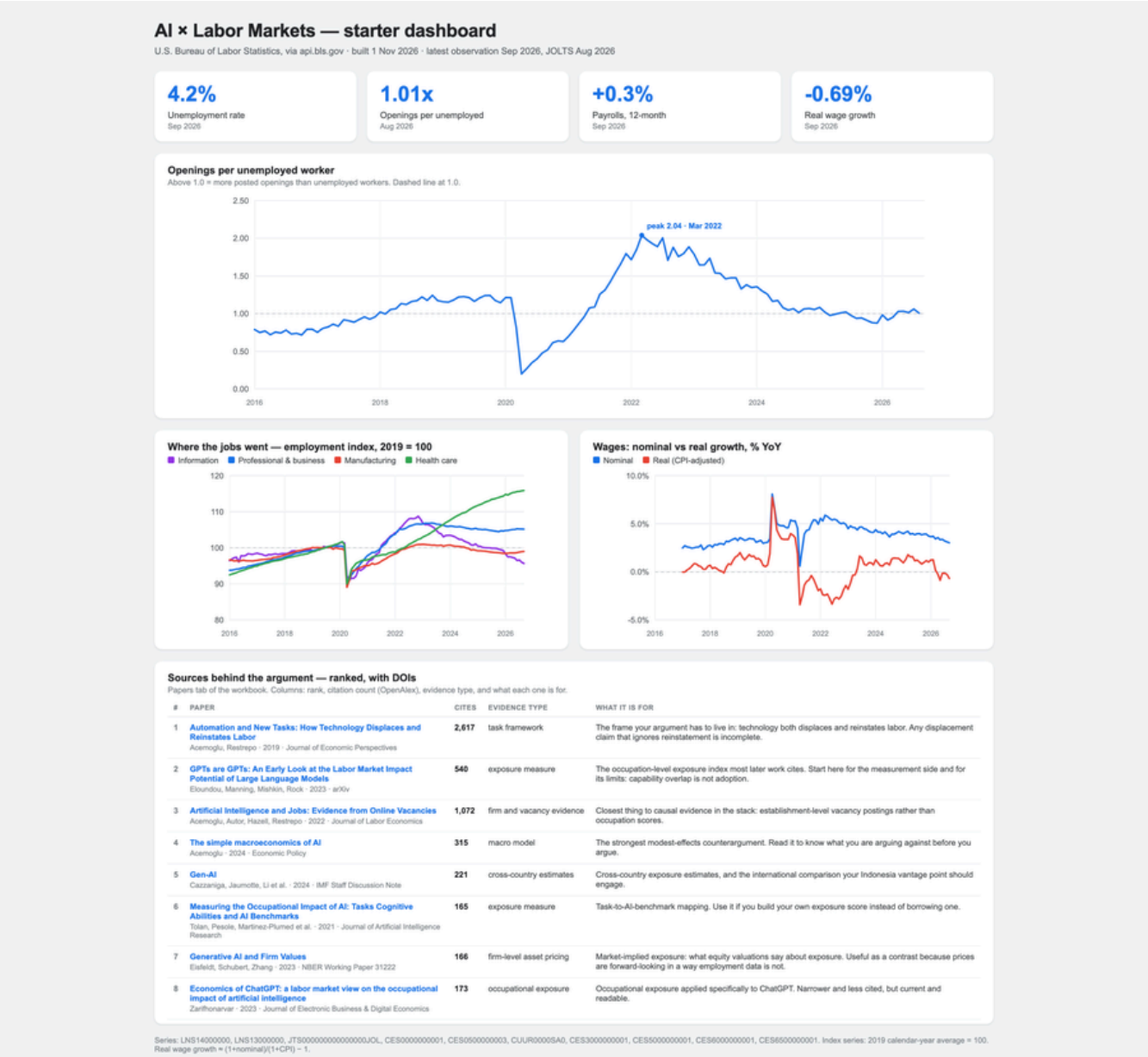
A descriptive chart pack, 129 months of U.S. data

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The dashboard



What this is

One hundred and twenty-nine monthly observations from January 2016 to September 2026, from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: employment by sector, job openings, unemployment, nominal and real wages. Four sectors are tracked: information, professional and business services, manufacturing, and health care and social assistance. Every number in the accompanying workbook is recomputed from the underlying series by a script in the package.

The findings

Information employment peaked in November 2022 at 108.77 on a 2019 = 100 index. By September 2026 it was 95.64: down 12.07 per cent from the peak, 4.36 per cent below its 2019 average, and 4.20 per cent below the same month a year earlier.

Health care and social assistance stood at 115.90: 15.90 per cent above its 2019 average and 25.31 per cent above January 2016. Same labour market, opposite direction, and still growing 1.88 per cent year over year.

Professional and business services peaked in May 2023 at 106.89 and was 105.17 in September 2026: only 1.61 per cent below peak, 5.17 per cent above 2019, and up 0.55 per cent over the year. The weakness is concentrated in information, not in cognitive work generally.

Manufacturing was 99.01, essentially flat: 0.99 per cent below its 2019 average and 0.32 per cent above a year earlier.

The labour market as a whole is growing slowly. Unemployment was 4.20 per cent in September 2026 and payrolls were up 0.31 per cent over twelve months. Nominal wage growth was 3.02 per cent against CPI inflation of 3.74 per cent, so real wages fell 0.69 per cent.

Job openings per unemployed worker were 1.01 in August 2026 (7,079 thousand openings against 7,031 thousand unemployed), down from a peak of 2.04 in March 2022. Labour demand has normalised.

What the pack cannot show

The information sector's decline is the most suggestive object in the pack, and it is easy to over-read. The peak is dated November 2022, the month ChatGPT was released. That coincidence is worth stating plainly, and it is not evidence. The same decline lines up with the end of pandemic-era over-hiring in technology, the sharp rise in the cost of capital from 2022, and the digital-advertising downturn that accompanied the rate cycle. Monthly sector data cannot separate those forces from AI adoption.

The pack says that plainly instead of picking a favourite cause. The accompanying papers take the next step: one tests the timing, one tests the hiring mechanism, and one tests whether firm disclosure about AI says anything about headcount.

Reproduce

The workbook, the underlying CSV and a verification script are included in the source package. Running the script prints every number quoted above and checks the arithmetic.